THE MISSING SCION



Where is **Tejashwi Yadav**, that's what all of Patna wants to know. The Rashtriya Janata Dal (RJD) chief leader wasn't there for the announcement of his party's candidate for the July 30 Bankipur bypoll, or during father Lalu Prasad's recent visit to a Patna hospital. He even missed the opening day of the assembly's monsoon session. MLC Neeraj Kumar of the ruling JD(U) quipped that the Opposition leader had perhaps "gone abroad to settle an international dispute". The RJD has also been coy about Tejashwi's whereabouts, which has only fuelled the speculation.

LOOMING EXIT DOOR



The whispers of an imminent Cabinet reshuffle have got at least a few central ministers on edge. One of them recently hosted a dinner for top officials, where the conversation reportedly turned nostalgic. Another has deferred public engagements and even rescheduled briefings on parliamentary replies. A third, known for taking files home and working late, has quietly begun returning them to his office in batches. As always, the only man who knows is the PM, and he's keeping his cards close to his chest.

BOARDING DENIED



Trinamool Congress No. 2 **Abhishek Banerjee** got a breather from the Calcutta High Court, but it's still a no for the boarding pass. On July 20, the court extended its 'protection from coercive action' order till October 6 in a case over his alleged 'DJ threat' during the Bengal poll campaign (the plaintiffs allege the reference to DJ sounds making the ears ring on results day was made to intimidate voters). The HC, though, refused his plea to travel abroad for eye treatment, asking for specialists at SSKM Hospital to first examine him and submit a report.

Kaushik Deka* with *Prasad Nichenametla*, *Ashish Misra*, *Amitabh Srivastava* and *Arkamoy Datta Majumdar

TECH WATCH

VIKRAM-I MAKES SPACE HISTORY

THE PRIVATE LEAP

By **Ajay Sukumaran**

Exactly 46 years after India's first experimental satellite launch vehicle, SLV-3, successfully lifted off from Sriharikota, the space port marked another historic moment: the maiden orbital rocket launch by an Indian private company.

Lifting off at 12:05 pm this July 18, Vikram-I, the small satellite launcher developed by Hyderabad-based unicorn startup Skyroot Aerospace, carried two satellites—SCOPE and Grahaa—apart from other payloads, and injected them to a low earth orbit (LEO). India is just the third country, after the US and China, to have a privately developed orbital rocket launch. The icing on the cake for Skyroot: getting it right on the first attempt. Even Elon Musk's SpaceX took four attempts to get Falcon-1 to orbit in 2008.

Skyroot, founded in 2018 by two IITians and ex-ISRO (Indian Space Research Organisation) hands, Pawan Kumar Chandana, 35, and Naga Bharath Daka, 36, flew its first test rocket in 2022. Subsequently, it developed Vikram-1 with three solid stages and a liquid stage to launch small satellites to LEO, with hand-holding by ISRO. With $160 million (Rs 1,541.3 crore) in funding so far, the start-up's stated mission is to redefine 'access to space' and fill a gap in the global launch market. The global space economy, valued at $596 billion in 2024, is



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projected to exceed $1.8 trillion by 2035. India's share in this market is now nearly 2 per cent, and is expected to reach 8 per cent over the next decade. According to Chandana, Skyroot is putting together four other rockets, and is targeting a second launch this year.